

The Effects of Historical Tourism: Investigating the Relationship between the Restoration of Colonial Williamsburg and Occupational Segregation Among the Black Population

Natalia Reinoso

Intro:

Growing research demonstrates how tourism economies often distribute uneven economic opportunities among social groups, concentrating marginalized populations in low-wage service jobs. Colonial Williamsburg serves as a case study to examine these dynamics because of its large impact on the local economy and complex relationship with race and gender roles at its period of restoration (early 1930s) which allowed for greater employment opportunities yet significant racial disparities. This study specifically investigates whether the restoration of Colonial Williamsburg can be associated with increased occupational segregation among Black workers within Virginia's historic triangle, which consists of Williamsburg, James City, and York Counties. Therefore, aiming to identify whether the transformation of Williamsburg into a tourism economy disproportionately resulted in Black workers taking lower status tourism and service occupations relative to white workers as tourism literature may suggest.

To evaluate this, the paper utilizes IPUMS census microdata from Virginia's Historic Triangle counties between 1910-1940 to compare pre-restoration period (1910-1930) and post-restoration (1940) labor market outcomes. The empirical strategy takes descriptive statistics and performs a regression analysis with before and after interaction terms to identify the likelihood that individuals changed fields to service-oriented, i.e. tourism influence, occupations. Results suggest inconclusive evidence that the restoration of Colonial Williamsburg coincided with expanding racially discriminative labor structures, though it could have potentially reinforcing pre-existing racial inequalities at the time.

Literature Review

Historical Background : Colonial Williamsburg and the Role of Race

Financed by John D. Rockefeller Jr., Colonial Williamsburg was reconstructed and made available to the public in the early 1930's as a living museum designed to represent an idealized 18th century capital. The project required extensive demolition, justified as cultural preservation and for regional economic development promising "spiritual" and "material" benefits . This resulted in the removal and reallocation of residents, completely reshaping the town's distribution of African American households and businesses particularly (Theobald, 2024). Some emphasize the restoration's success due to the employment and education opportunities available for Black residents, particularly crucial during the great depression. However, the large displacement of homes/institutions occupied by the Black population further contributed to pre-existing segregation in the area due to Jim Crow laws (Theobald,2024). Pre-restoration Williamsburg was driven by selective historical visions prioritizing white colonial narratives, and continued such patterns post restoration as well.

Research addresses that Colonial Williamsburg initially functioned to preserve ideologies that magnified the importance of white figures while marginalizing enslaved African Americans and their descendants (Greenspan, 1994). Though Black residents played crucial roles to the original economy and construction, their experiences during [actual] colonial Williamsburg were initially excluded from the museum's narrative and only incorporated much later. This aligns with the perspective that the site served more as a historical falsification, commercializing on the phenomenon of historical tourism popularity (Miller, 2006). Such attractions and historic driven activities encouraged surrounding counties as well to become economically interconnected

through heritage tourism. Thus, eventually creating Virginia's "historic Triangle" of which Colonial Williamsburg, Jamestown, and Yorktown are central destinations (Huh & Uyal, 2004)

Contrary to some belief, African American labor was visible in the museum, even serving as staples to the tour experience by taking on iconic roles such as coachmen (Edwards-Ingram, 2014). However, they were treated as nearly invisible, and remained constrained to lower status occupations that reinforced notions of submissive/servitude stereotypes among the black population to create an "authentic" atmosphere (Edwards-Ingram, 2014). The attempt to commodify this public experience would insinuate that tourism did play some role in occupational segregation rather than simply Jim Crow laws, as the black population was still highly visible in the economic processes (Miller, 2006). This frames the potential effectiveness of investigating racialized labor hierarchies in a tourism context rather than solely the historically segregated south, though it simultaneously played a large role.

Tourism Economies: Occupational Inequality Patterns

Though most literature highlights the advantages of tourism centered economies due to gains in employment and regional income, growing bodies of research challenge the real value of these benefits by observing how occupation is distributed differently among social groups.

Recent findings demonstrate that tourism development is often associated with restructuring local labor markets to concentrate employment in low-wage, low mobility occupations. In a study by Kronenberg & Fuchs, they use a regional Swedish tourism economy to demonstrate how increases in tourist demands led to unproportional employment growth. Though their results also indicated tourism's positive impact on total employment, over time "elementary", low-skill service occupations [such as cleaning, food preparation, and hospitality]

dominated the labor market in comparison to managerial and higher education roles (Kronenberg & Fuchs, 2021). Income inequality also steadily increased, particularly due to wage stagnation among lower tier occupations. Therefore, the study highlights the limitations of traditional input-output models, which focus on total employment and income effects as indicators of positive impacts of tourism, by providing an alternative approach addressing the unequal distribution of occupations due to tourism. These findings provide an important framework for the current study and guide the hypothesis suggesting that while increasing tourism in Colonial Williamsburg could have elevated economic growth, it also could have unequally distributed occupational advancement across racial groups.

Other research on tourism-dependent economies in the US also suggest that tourism-driven growth is often associated with increased income inequality, particularly in regards to race. In their analysis of nonmetropolitan counties, Lee and O'Leary find that recreation dependent regions demonstrate higher levels of income inequality than manufacturing dependent areas. The author describes this pattern as largely driven by the structure of tourism labor markets, again emphasizing concentrations of low-wage/skill service occupations generating wide earnings gaps between workers and ownership positions. The study adds how these dynamics are closely related to race using a "race dualism" measure to account for inequality generated between Black and White households in a county. Their results present that the variable has a positive relationship with income inequality, suggesting that racial differences play a large role in increasing inequalities. It can also be noted that historically the US South shows a high proportion of Black and low income populations. Interestingly though, their results demonstrate a positive relationship between the South region and income inequality regardless of community, suggesting there are other regional variables to consider in regards to

occupational/income inequalities in the South. These findings support the relevance of examining Colonial Williamsburg by suggesting that tourism economies in the South may have preexisting racial hierarchies that disproportionately affect Black workers to go into service occupations while simultaneously motivating investigating other potential causes of such inequalities, such as tourism.

Incoming research also illustrates how the nature of tourism occupation allocation is not incidental but instead structurally embedded in how tourism is organized (Christian, 2015). In an analysis of tourism in Kenya, Michelle Christian compares the roles of the Maasai Mara and the Maasai people. While the Maasai Mara is an elite tourism firm largely controlled by white Kenyans in high value positions due to cultural perceptions of professionalism, the Maasai men and women are often disproportionately concentrated in lower paid service and performance roles. The author notes this division is reinforced through "representations" of authenticity, where the Maasai identity is commodified as a tourist attraction which therefore traps them in expected cultural roles. Therefore, even when local communities experience forms of income growth, the upgrade is uneven and often reinforces existing racial and gender hierarchies rather than dismantling them. This is especially relevant to Colonial Williamsburg as the initial restoration period similarly attempted to recreate an "authentic" historical environment. This system may have encouraged concentration of Black workers in behind the scenes labor/service roles to support the tourist experience and maintain gender norms.

Together, the literature demonstrates that tourism development is not inherently beneficial, and often distributes economic opportunities disproportionately especially within occupation. The paper builds on these findings by examining whether the restoration of Colonial Williamsburg demonstrated occupational inequalities between Black and White workers. By

examining occupational distributions before and after the restoration period the study seeks to also determine whether tourism in Williamsburg reinforced racialized labor hierarchies by disproportionately allocating Black workers into low wage and value service occupations in comparison to White workers.

Data/Methods

This study analyzes census microdata from the Integrated Public Use Microdata Series (IPUMS) to examine whether the restoration of Colonial Williamsburg corresponded with increased occupational segregation among Black workers within the Virginia counties Williamsburg, York, and James City. These counties (from countyicp) were selected due to their proximity to Colonial Williamsburg and relevance towards the area's historic tourism economy, suggesting that the site likely aided in expanding the economy of said counties. Previous research has similarly interconnected these counties as a tourism region as well (Huh & Uyal, 2004).

A before and after analysis design is used to evaluate occupational distribution changes, rather than a complete difference in difference or time series regression, emphasizing that results cannot be interpreted as strictly causal, and instead establish potential relationships between the variables. The analysis focuses on Black and White workers between 1910-1940, using IPUMS extract to restrict the sample to only include two race groups since they represented a majority of the population at that time period/location. The timeframe is divided into a “pre-restoration” and “post-restoration” period containing observations from 1910-1930 and 1940 respectively (from year). This is intended to reflect the time period prior to and during Rockefeller’s project and compare it to the commercialized tourism of the area which followed after.

Using occ1950 classifications, the primary dependent variable (tourism_job) was constructed. As previous tourism literature addressed, there are significant limitations when using (Input Output models which rely on assumptions of what classifies as a tourism job since there is no direct census measurement for tourism fields. Therefore there is always risk for potential under or overestimation of what occupations to consider. Occupations under the label "Service Workers (not household)" as well as Ticket, station, and express agents" and "Attendants, auto service and parking" were selected from occ1950 to serve as proxy tourism variables in this study based on the historical context illustrating the role of service jobs increasing for both Colonial Williamsburg and tourism locations in general, along with transportation jobs. The tourism_job variable is a binary variable, indicating 1 if an individual worked in the selected occupations associated with tourism, and 0 if otherwise.

The primary independent variable is "black," a dummy variable coded as 1 if an individual is Black and 0 if an individual is white. "Post" serves as the identification whether an observation occurred post restoration, therefore 1940 would be coded as 1 as 1910-1930 considered as 0. Thus the interaction term black*post estimates whether black workers experienced a change to a tourism associated occupation.

Lastly, the analysis controls for age and occupational income scores. Age is included to account for potential differences in labor participation and experience, where people who maintained the occupation longer have advantages in occupational value scores or disadvantages such as with physical jobs. Occscore serves as a proxy for occupational economic status potential earning scores, which is included to evaluate if tourism related employment is associated with low-status occupations.

Descriptive statistics

Utilizing descriptive statistics for information in occscore and occ1950, there is a substantial amount of occupation observations coded as “N/A (blank)”. Non applicable accounts for over half of the recorded occupations (62%), reflecting unassigned, suppressed, or genuinely not applicable occupations within these counties and time period. Both racial groups have similar shares of missing occupational classification in respective to their own race, where White individuals have 155 observations out of 257 classified as N/A while Black individuals have 222 out of 347 observations. As a result, only a fraction of the sample contains usable information, even less so regarding tourism related employment and occupational income scores. Therefore, the results will have a large reduction in outcome effectiveness, however an analysis regarding relative differences can still be observed to investigate any potential distribution patterns.

Table 1: Summary Statistics : Race and Gender within the sample

Variable	White Men	Black Men	White Women	Black Women
age (avg)	33.97	25.79	31.64	24.22
tourism_job	.02	.03	.01	.03
occscore	13.76	9.57	2.46	1.76
observation	180	141	167	116

With the little sample data that is available, several patterns are noticeable. Primarily, tourism related employment is considered very limited across all groups, accounting for 3% or less of occupations among all groups. Though the Black men and women have slightly higher percentages in tourism_jobs, they do not have higher occupation scores. This would indicate that the White population, specifically men, retain higher status occupations on average at 13.76%. Black women average the lowest observations and relative scores other than the tourism_job

variable. This suggests that black female labor was disproportionately concentrated or unaccounted for - also potentially reinforcing the argument that tourism economy did not distribute opportunities equally and instead continued the notion of pre-existing gender and racial hierarchies.

Strategy

The primary model style regression framework specified as;

$$\text{ServiceJob} = B_0 + B_1\text{Black} + B_2\text{Post} + B_3(\text{Black}*\text{Post}) + B_4\text{Age} + B_5\text{Occscore} + e$$

Where tourist_job represents whether an individual worked in an allocated tourist occupations (service or transportation), Black identifies black workers, post identifies post restoration observations, the interaction term (black*Post) estimates the differential post restoration effect on black workers, age controls for life cycle labor differences, and occscore controls for occupational economic status.

The same regression model is estimated for men and women separately to evaluate and account for the occupational segregation variation across gender likely due to historical background. This is relevant as the labor opportunities for male/female population differed particularly during Jim Crow laws where black women often coincided with home roles. OLS with robust standard errors is used to estimate these differences.

LIMITATIONS:

Numerous limitations should be acknowledged regarding the study. Again, occupational classifications available through IPUMS do not directly identify tourism employment, therefore service occupation variables are constructed through proxy occupations. This makes it heavily reliant on previous literature and predictions that service and transportation jobs are associated

with tourism in regards to Colonial Williamsburg. Second, the Historic Triangle counties have incredibly small population samples during early census years. Therefore, there is a significant limitation in the precision of results that could reduce the relevance of regression estimates. Third, the study cannot establish causal relationships between Colonial Williamsburg's restoration and occupational outcomes due to historical issues regarding racial differences such as the heavily segregated south, Jim Crow practices in Virginia, and other potential changes in Virginia adapting to post civil war. Therefore, the results won't return a clear answer regarding if tourism alone is influencing occupational patterns, however it can provide information regarding creating a framework for observing the potential long term effects of historical tourism on occupational segregation. Fourth, a major limitation arises from inconsistencies in county level geographic identifications within the IPUMS census. The 1950. census extract does not contain consistent usable county level identifiers for Williamsburg, James, and York counties, only providing much broader interpretations which decrease the reliability of including 1950 in the analysis to measure tourism post restoration. The amount of observations within the counties were already small, therefore the limitation in years continues to drastically cut sample size, which will likely affect results. This also creates an uneven timeframe design, where pre-restoration follows a 30 year period while post restoration sees a little less than a full 10 year difference between when the site was made public (early 1930s). Thus only a short/medium run labor market change can be measured rather than accomplishing an analysis on potential long run tourism effects. However, one could also argue 1940 serves as an appropriate way to identify early tourism labor market changes due to its close alignment with the period Colonial Williamsburg became operational. Finally, large amounts of missing or unusable data in the

sample. Not only through occupation scores, but also education scores such as edscore50.

Therefore, trying to control for things such as years/value of education is difficult

Further research with more complete geographic data, and likely entirely different analysis, would be necessary to assess longer term effects.

Empirical Analysis

Table 2: Proportion of Individuals Employed in “tourism” occupation

Year	White Workers	Black Workers	Total
1910	0.016	0.021	0.018
1920	0.018	0.015	0.017
1930	0.000	0.015	0.007
1940	0.029	0.064	0.044
Total	0.017	0.031	0.023

Reiterating the previous descriptive statistical understanding but now observing its changes through time period demonstrates that Black workers occupied larger shares of tourism related jobs primarily during the year 1940, potentially supporting the notion that post restoration Colonial Williamsburg may have disproportionately affected the Black population. About 6.4% of black workers occupied service sector positions compared to 2.9% of white workers in 1940. Though this seems like a significant leap, understanding the amount of data that has unusable values makes it unclear whether this change was correlated with more information.

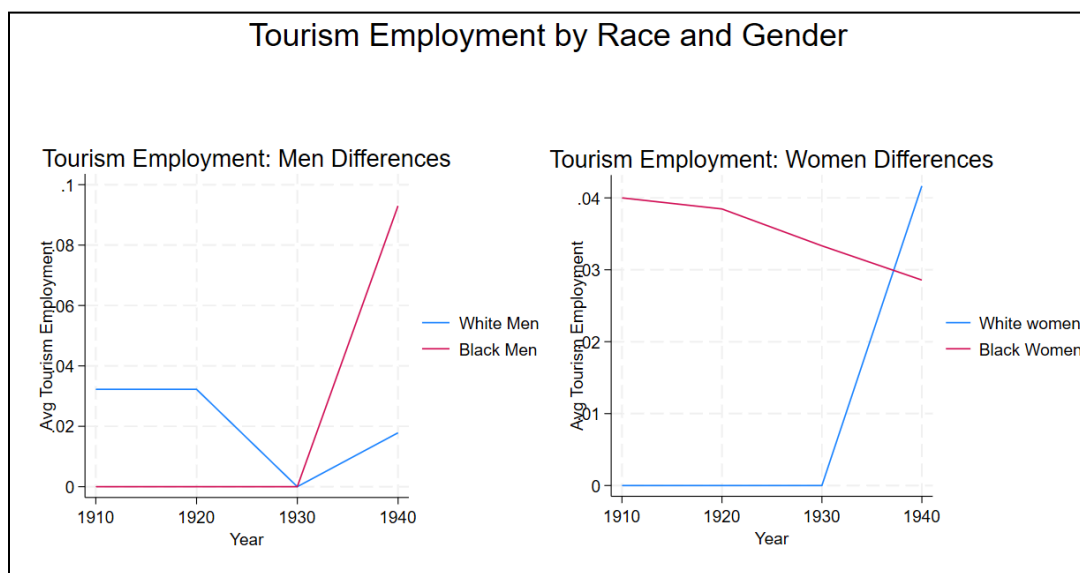


Figure 1: Average share of employment at tourism associated occupation through 1910-1940

Men vs Women

tourism_job	Coefficient	Robust std. err.	t	P> t	[95% conf. interval]	
black 1	-.0179103	.0116758	-1.53	0.126	-.0408828	.0050622
post Post-Restoration	-.0112739	.0240411	-0.47	0.639	-.0585753	.0360275
black#post 1#Post-Restoration	.1019264	.0509499	2.00	0.046	.0016813	.2021716
age	.0003132	.0003371	0.93	0.354	-.0003502	.0009765
occscore	.0010817	.0006175	1.75	0.081	-.0001332	.0022967
_cons	.0002007	.0120173	0.02	0.987	-.0234436	.0238451

Figure 2: Regression for Men

The regression analysis provides additional evidence supporting this previous trend among male workers. In the male regression model the interaction term is positive and

statistically significant ($p = 0.046$). The coefficient indicates that Black men experienced approximately a 10.2% greater increase in service sector employment following restoration relative to white men. This result could potentially provide evidence that the growth of colonial Williamsburg tourism economy disproportionately affected black male labor by fitting them into tourism oriented occupations after restoration.

tourism_job	Coefficient	Robust std. err.	t	P> t	[95% conf. interval]	
black 1	.0395737	.0212105	1.87	0.063	-.0021805	.081328
post Post-Restoration	.021454	.0273229	0.79	0.433	-.0323329	.0752409
black#post 1#Post-Restoration	-.0305338	.0421831	-0.72	0.470	-.1135739	.0525064
age	.000513	.0004234	1.21	0.227	-.0003206	.0013465
occscore	.0061957	.0027646	2.24	0.026	.0007534	.0116379
_cons	-.0256689	.0141485	-1.81	0.071	-.053521	.0021833

Figure 3: Regression for women

On the other hand, the female regression model demonstrates no statistical significance ($p = 0.47$) and thus little evidence of an effect post restoration. Though, based on table 1, Black women remained more likely than white women to work in service occupations overall, the post restoration interaction term does not suggest that restoration generated a large additional increase in service employment among Black women relative to White women. Therefore no conclusive results can be analyzed. Instead it's important to acknowledge the limitations of the study, especially in regards to women and the overall occupation, which can be expected when using historical data.

Numerous limitations remain with the interpretation of these findings. Many regression coefficients fail to achieve strong statistical significance likely due to the small sample size of the countries especially during early census years. Additionally the study cannot isolate tourism employment because service sector occupations may also include non tourism labor. Finally, broad economic and political developments throughout Virginia during the Jim Crow period likely influenced occupational outcomes along with tourism, making the results lose causality.

Conclusion:

Results suggest that there is a possibility that the restoration of Colonial Williamsburg may have coincided with occupational segregation patterns, however a causal relationship and significant results cannot be interpreted from the current data set. The descriptive statistics at least offer a confirmation of previous studies by indicating how black workers were more likely to appear in tourist (service) occupations while simultaneously having lower status. The study also offers an attempt at addressing the inequalities created in tourism driven economies which is not measured in many non recent studies. However, a lot of consideration would need to take place regarding defining more proxy variables to address cultural, geographical, and historical impacts that could affect social inequalities outside of tourism.

Future studies would need stronger/more complete county level census data, potentially meaning looking at Williamsburg, James, and York county records specifically, or using an alternative tourism location.

References

1. Kronenberg, K., & Fuchs, M. (2021). The socio-economic impact of regional tourism: an occupation-based modelling perspective from Sweden. *Journal of Sustainable Tourism*, 1–21. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09669582.2021.1924757>
2. Lee, S., & O’Leary, J. T. (2008). Determinants of Income Inequality in U.S. Nonmetropolitan Tourism- and Recreation-Dependent Communities. *Journal of Travel Research*, 46(4), 456–468. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0047287507312425>
3. CHRISTIAN, M. (2015). Kenya’s tourist industry and global production networks: gender, race and inequality. *Global Networks*, 16(1), 25–44. <https://doi.org/10.1111/glob.12094>
4. Edwards-Ingram, Y. (2014). Slavery, race, and visibility: Before 1979: African American coachmen, visibility, and representation at Colonial Williamsburg. *The Public Historian*, 36(1), 9–35. <https://doi.org/10.1525/tph.2014.36.1.9>
5. MILLER, J. S. (2006). Mapping the Boosterist Imaginary: Colonial Williamsburg, Historical Tourism, and the Construction of Managerial Memory. *The Public Historian*, 28(4), 51–74. <https://doi.org/10.1525/tph.2006.28.4.51>
6. Greenspan, A. (1994). How philanthropy can alter our view of the past: a look at Colonial Williamsburg. *Voluntas (Manchester, England)*, 5(2), 193–203. <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF02353985>
7. Huh, J., & Uysal, M. (2004). Satisfaction with Cultural/Heritage Sites: Virginia Historic Triangle. *Current Issues and Development in Hospitality and Tourism Satisfaction*, 4(3–4), 177–194. https://doi.org/10.1300/J162v04n03_12
8. Theobald, M. (2024). African Americans and the Restoration of Williamsburg. [Colonialwilliamsburg.org. https://research.colonialwilliamsburg.org/Foundation/journal/Summer14/restoration.cfm](https://research.colonialwilliamsburg.org/Foundation/journal/Summer14/restoration.cfm)
9. Steven Ruggles, Sarah Flood, Matthew Sobek, Daniel Backman, Grace Cooper, Julia A. Rivera Drew, Stephanie Richards, Renae Rodgers, Jonathan Schroeder, and Kari C.W. Williams. *IPUMS USA: Version 16.0* [dataset]. Minneapolis, MN: IPUMS, 2025. <https://doi.org/10.18128/D010.V16.0>